**Effective Date:**
January 1, 2026

**Background:**
Employees in California are required to be paid the minimum wage as required by state law, with certain exemptions. The current California minimum wage is $16.50 per hour.

**Purpose:**
To inform staff of the increase in the statewide minimum wage and its impact on CalWORKs, CalFresh, Employment Services, CalFresh Employment & Training (CFET), and General Relief Work Project assignment and credit.

**Policy:**
Effective January 1, 2026, the California minimum wage will increase to $16.90 per hour. Refer to CalWORKs Program Guide (CPG) 44-270.F and CalFresh Program Guide (CFPG) 63-251 for guidance on Prospective Budgeting and Reasonably Anticipated Income. See General Relief Program Guide (GRPG) 90-700.8 for General Relief Work Project assignment and credit.

**Procedure:**
CalWORKs and CalFresh Programs
Individuals are expected to report income reflecting the minimum wage increase beginning in the Eligibility Status Report (SAR 7) data month of January 2026 or the Redetermination/Recertification (RE) month of February 2026.

Customers are required to report mid-period when their income exceeds their Income Reporting Threshold (IRT). If the customer reports a pay increase prior to January 1, 2026, use current reporting regulations to determine when the change of income should be used in the budget.

For further guidance on:
- Mandatory Mid-Period Reports refer to CPG 44-270.C and CFPG 63-283.
- Voluntary Mid-Period Reports refer to CPG 44-270.H and CFPG 63-284.

Employment Services
Employment Case Managers (ECMs) must perform the Simplified CalFresh Program (SCFP) calculation to determine the maximum number of hours that a participant can be required to participate in a Work Experience (WEX) or Community Service (CS) assignment. ECMs must continue using the minimum wage of $16.50 when completing such a calculation through December 31, 2025. Refer to CPG 10-050.A and CalWORKs Processing Guide No. 10-050.A1 for further guidance.

CalFresh Employment & Training and General Relief Work Project
Work Project assignments are determined by dividing the net CalFresh allotment by the federal or state minimum wage, whichever is higher. As the current California minimum wage is higher than the federal minimum wage, use the new California minimum wage for the number of Work Project days assigned, effective January 2026 and ongoing.

For example: A single employable customer living alone with no income will receive the maximum CalFresh allotment of $292 ÷ $16.90 = 17.28. Hours are rounded down to the nearest eight-hour increment. The customer will be assigned 16 hours.

The General Relief Employable Program aligns with the CFET policy. Any remainder of the General Relief benefit will still show as an amount owed to the county when the case closes.

The credit for Work Project hours completed is determined by multiplying the number of hours worked by the current federal or state minimum wage, whichever is higher.

For example: Using the example above, the customer worked 16 hours each month. 16 hours x $16.90 = $270 repaid per month.

Please refer to Attachment A for a reference table of the number of Work Project days to be assigned based on the corresponding CalFresh allotment amounts.

**Impacts:**
None.

**References:**
All County Information Notice (ACIN) No. I-45-25.

**Sunset Date:**
This policy will be reviewed for continuance by January 31, 2027.

**Approval for Release:**



Alberto Banuelos, Ph.D., Interim Director
Self-Sufficiency Services

## ATTACHMENT A

## GENERAL RELIEF WORK PROJECT DAYS

| Work Project Days Assigned | CalFresh Allotment |
|---|---|
| 0 Days | $0 - $135 |
| 1 Day | $136 - $270 |
| 2 Days | $271 - $292 |